

Complete Viva Study Guide

All 6 Topics Combined in Simple English

Topics: Phonetics & Phonology • Phonemes & Phones • Syllable & Phonotactics • Connected Speech • Strong/Weak Forms • IPA Transcription

Table of Contents

1. **Phonetics and Phonology** — Definitions, Differences, Classification & Correlation
2. **Phonemes, Phones & Allophones** — Definitions, Differences & Theories
3. **Syllable** — Phonetic vs. Phonological Definitions & Phonotactics
4. **Connected Speech** — Rules and Processes
5. **Strong vs. Weak Forms** — Contractions, Elision & Assimilation
6. **IPA Transcription of Connected Speech**
7. **Combined Viva Question Bank** — All Topics

Phonetics and Phonology: Definitions, Differences, Classification & Correlation

1.1 What is Phonetics?

Definition

Phonetics is the scientific study of how humans physically produce, transmit, and hear speech sounds. It does not depend on any specific language — it is universal.

Think of phonetics as the "hardware" of speech. It looks at what your mouth, tongue, lips, and vocal cords actually do when you make sounds.

Three Branches of Phonetics

1. **Articulatory Phonetics** — How we physically produce sounds using our mouth, tongue, lips, etc. This is the most important branch for ELT teachers because we need to show students where to put their tongue.
2. **Acoustic Phonetics** — How sound waves travel through the air (frequency, pitch, loudness). Studied with spectrograms in labs.
3. **Auditory Phonetics** — How our ears and brain receive and decode speech sounds.

1.2 What is Phonology?

Definition

Phonology is the study of how sounds work within a specific language's mental system. It looks at which sounds can change meaning and what rules govern their combination.

Think of phonology as the "software" — the mental rules in your brain. For example, English treats /p/ and /b/ as different sounds because swapping them changes meaning (*pin* vs *bin*). But in Arabic, [p] is just a variant of /b/.

1.3 Key Differences: Phonetics vs Phonology

Feature	Phonetics	Phonology
Nature	Physical, concrete, measurable	Abstract, mental, cognitive
Core Question	"How is this sound physically made?"	"How does this sound function in the language?"
Scope	Universal (all languages)	Language-specific
Basic Unit	Phone — a physical sound	Phoneme — a mental sound unit
Notation	Square brackets: []	Slash brackets: / /
Branches	Articulatory, Acoustic, Auditory	Segmental, Suprasegmental

1.4 How are Phonetics and Phonology Related?

They need each other. Phonetics gives the raw physical data; Phonology gives the mental rules that organize those sounds into a meaningful system. Without Phonetics, Phonology has no physical basis. Without Phonology, Phonetics is just meaningless noise data.

1.5 Graphemes vs Phonemes: Why English Spelling is Tricky

A **grapheme** is a written letter (<c> , <ph>). A **phoneme** is a spoken sound (/k/ , /f/). In English, there is **no one-to-one match** between letters and sounds:

- The letter <c> can be /k/ (*cut*), /s/ (*nice*), or /ʃ/ (*ocean*)
- The sound /i:/ has 7+ spellings: *he*, *believe*, *Caesar*, *see*, *people*, *seize*, *seas*
- The -ough spelling has 7 different sounds: *tough* /ʌf/, *cough* /ɒf/, *bough* /aʊ/, *though* /əʊ/, *through* /u:/, *borough* /ə/, *hiccough* /ʌp/

George Bernard Shaw's joke: "GHOTI" = "FISH" (gh from *tough* = /f/, o from *women* = /ɪ/, ti from *nation* = /ʃ/).

Homophones vs Homographs

- **Homophones:** Same sound, different spelling — *sea* /si:/ vs *see* /si:/
- **Homographs:** Same spelling, different sound — *lead* /li:d/ (guide) vs *lead* /led/ (metal)

1.6 The IPA (International Phonetic Alphabet)

Founded in **1886** by **Paul Passy**. Golden Rule: "One symbol for one sound, and one sound for one symbol."

Why ELT Teachers Need the IPA

1. **Look-up:** Find correct pronunciation in dictionaries
2. **Diagnosis:** Identify exactly which sound a student gets wrong
3. **Explanation:** Teach stress, weak forms, and connected speech clearly
4. **Materials:** Create pronunciation drills and worksheets

Broad vs Narrow Transcription

Feature	Broad (Phonemic) / /	Narrow (Phonetic) []
Purpose	Shows only meaning-changing sounds	Shows fine articulatory details
Diacritics	None	Uses marks for aspiration, dental, etc.
Example	<i>cat</i> → /kæt/	<i>cat</i> → [kʰæt̚]

Key Transcription Symbols

- ' = Primary stress (before the stressed syllable): /'ɪmpɔ:tənt/
- , = Secondary stress: /,ɪntə'næʃnəl/
- : = Long vowel: /i:/ , /u:/
- ŋ , ɫ = Syllabic consonants: *button* /'bʌt̚n/ , *little* /'lɪt̚l/

1.7 Organs of Speech

Humans don't have special "speech organs." We use breathing and eating organs to produce speech:

- **Lungs** — Air source (all English sounds use pulmonic egressive airstream)
- **Larynx & Vocal Cords** — Voicing (vibrating = voiced, open = voiceless)
- **Tongue** — Most flexible organ (Tip, Blade, Front, Back, Root)
- **Lips** — Spread, neutral, or rounded
- **Palate** — Hard palate (fixed) and Soft palate/Velum (moves up/down)
- **Alveolar Ridge** — The bumpy ridge behind upper front teeth
- **Teeth** — Upper and lower front teeth

Active articulators (move): tongue, lower lip. **Passive articulators** (stay still): upper teeth, alveolar ridge, hard palate.

Velum up = oral sound (most sounds). **Velum down** = nasal sound (/m, n, ŋ/).

1.8 Classification of English Consonants (24 sounds)

Every consonant is described using **3 parameters**:

1. **Voicing**: Voiced (vocal cords vibrate) or Voiceless (no vibration)
2. **Place**: WHERE the blockage happens in the mouth
3. **Manner**: HOW the air is blocked or released

8 Places of Articulation

Place	What Touches What	Sounds
Bilabial	Both lips together	/p, b, m, w/
Labiodental	Lower lip + upper teeth	/f, v/
Dental	Tongue tip + upper teeth	/θ, ð/
Alveolar	Tongue tip/blade + alveolar ridge	/t, d, s, z, n, l/
Post-alveolar	Tongue behind alveolar ridge	/ʃ, ʒ, tʃ, dʒ, r/
Palatal	Front of tongue + hard palate	/j/
Velar	Back of tongue + soft palate	/k, g, ŋ, w/
Glottal	Vocal cords in the larynx	/h/

6 Manners of Articulation

Manner	How Air Comes Out	Sounds
Plosive (Stop)	Complete blockage then sudden burst	/p, b, t, d, k, g/
Affricate	Blockage then slow friction release	/tʃ, dʒ/
Fricative	Narrow gap causes continuous hissing	/f, v, θ, ð, s, z, ʃ, ʒ, h/
Nasal	Mouth blocked, air exits through nose	/m, n, ŋ/
Lateral	Tongue blocks center, air flows around sides	/l/
Approximant	Organs close but no friction	/w, r, j/

Full 24-Consonant Chart

Manner ↓ \ Place →	Bilabial	Labio-dental	Dental	Alveolar	Post-alveolar	Palatal	Velar	Glottal
Plosive	p b			t d			k g	
Affricate					tʃ dʒ			
Fricative		f v	θ ð	s z	ʃ ʒ			h
Nasal	m			n			ŋ	
Lateral				l				
Approximant	(w)				r	j	(w)	

(Left of each cell = voiceless, Right = voiced. /w/ is labio-velar — both bilabial and velar at the same time.)

1.9 Classification of English Vowels (20 sounds)

Vowels are produced with **no blockage** of airflow. All vowels are **voiced**. They are described by 4 features:

1. **Tongue Height:** Close (high), Mid, Open (low)
2. **Tongue Position:** Front, Central, Back
3. **Lip Shape:** Spread, Neutral, Rounded
4. **Length:** Long (tense) or Short (lax)

12 Monophthongs (Pure Vowels)

IPA	Type	Description	Example Words
/i:/	Long	Close front spread	tea, see, sheep
/ɪ/	Short	Near-close near-front lax	ship, bit, fill
/e/	Short	Close-mid front spread (no long pair)	ten, wet, left
/æ/	Short	Open front spread (no long pair)	cat, man, apple
/ʌ/	Short	Open-mid central neutral	sun, up, cut
/ɑ:/	Long	Open back neutral	car, fast, dark
/ɒ/	Short	Open back rounded	hot, clock, dog
/ɔ:/	Long	Open-mid back rounded	door, four, saw
/ʊ/	Short	Near-close near-back rounded	put, good, wool
/u:/	Long	Close back rounded	you, too, blue
/ɜ:/	Long	Mid central neutral (long schwa)	bird, girl, learn
/ə/	Short	Mid central neutral (Schwa — most common English sound)	about, paper, over

The Schwa /ə/ — The King of English Sounds

The schwa is the **most frequent vowel** in English. It appears in every unstressed syllable. Your mouth is completely relaxed — neutral lips, neutral tongue. Words like *to*, *of*, *a*, *the*, *and* all use schwa in normal speech.

8 Diphthongs (Gliding Vowels)

A diphthong starts at one vowel position and glides to another within a single syllable.

Type	IPA	Example
Centring (→ /ə/)	/ɪə/	hear, dear
	/eə/	hair, chair
	/ʊə/	pure, tour
Closing (→ /ɪ/)	/eɪ/	face, day
	/aɪ/	price, my
	/ɔɪ/	boy, choice
Closing (→ /ʊ/)	/əʊ/	goat, home
	/aʊ/	mouth, now

5 Triphthongs

A closing diphthong + schwa: /eɪə/ (*player*), /aɪə/ (*fire*), /ɔɪə/ (*royal*), /əʊə/ (*slower*), /aʊə/ (*power*).

1.10 RP vs General American

Feature	RP (British)	General American
Post-vocalic /r/	Silent: <i>car</i> /kɑ:/	Pronounced: <i>car</i> /kɑ:r/
/ɒ/ vowel	Exists: <i>pot</i> /pɒt/	Merged with /ɑ:/: <i>pot</i> /pɑ:t/
BATH vowel	/ɑ:/: <i>bath</i> /bɑ:θ/	/æ/: <i>bath</i> /bæθ/
Intervocalic /t/	Clear [t]: <i>water</i> ['wɔ:tə]	Flapped [ɾ]: <i>water</i> ['wɑ:rər]

Phonemes, Phones & Allophones: Definitions, Differences & Theories

2.1 Three Core Concepts

Phone — Notation: []

Any speech sound as a physical, acoustic event. It can be measured with instruments. Example: aspirated [p^h] and unaspirated [p] are two different phones.

Phoneme — Notation: / /

The smallest abstract sound unit in a language that can change meaning. It lives in the speaker's mind. Example: /p/ vs /b/ — swapping them changes *pat* to *bat*. So /p/ and /b/ are separate phonemes.

Allophone — Notation: []

A predictable variant of a phoneme that depends on context. It **never** changes meaning. Example: [p^h] (in *pin*) and [p] (in *spin*) are allophones of the phoneme /p/.

Quick Comparison

Feature	Phone	Phoneme	Allophone
Nature	Concrete, physical	Abstract, mental	Contextual variant
Notation	[]	/ /	[]
Changes meaning?	N/A	Yes	No
How to identify	Acoustic observation	Minimal pairs / Commutation test	Distributional analysis

2.2 Key Tests

Minimal Pair Test: Two words that differ by only one sound in the same position and have different meanings (e.g., *cat* vs *bat*) → the differing sounds are separate phonemes.

Commutation Test (Trubetzkoy): Swap one sound for another. If meaning changes → phonemes. If only pronunciation style changes → allophones.

Complementary Distribution: Two allophones never appear in the same environment. [p^h] only appears syllable-initially, [p] only appears after /s/. They are in complementary distribution.

2.3 Five Major Theories (Covered in Class)

1. Daniel Jones (1881–1967) — Foundations of Phonetics

British phonetician at UCL. Helped build the IPA. Created the **Cardinal Vowels** system — 8 universal reference points for describing vowels based on extreme tongue positions. These don't belong to any specific language.

2. Nikolai Trubetzkoy (1890–1938) — Birth of Phonology

Founder of the Prague Linguistic Circle (1926). Published *Grundzüge der Phonologie* (Principles of Phonology, 1939). Key contributions:

- Separated Phonetics (physical sounds) from Phonology (mental sound system)

- **Neutralization:** When two phonemes lose their contrast in a specific position (e.g., German *Rad* /d/ and *Rat* /t/ both become [t] at the end of a word)
- **Archiphoneme:** Written with a capital letter (e.g., /T/) to represent the neutralized pair

3. Roman Jakobson (1896–1982) — Distinctive Features

Proved that sounds are not invisible atoms but **bundles of binary features**. Each feature is either present [+] or absent [-]:

- [$\pm$ voiced] : /b/ [+voiced] vs /p/ [-voiced]
- [$\pm$ nasal] : /m/ [+nasal] vs /b/ [-nasal]
- [$\pm$ continuant] : /f/ [+continuant] vs /p/ [-continuant]

4. Noam Chomsky (1928–) — Generative Phonology

Saw language as a mental system. Phonology = mental grammar rules that derive what we actually say:

Underlying Form (UR) → [Phonological Rules] → Surface Form (SR)

5. Morris Halle (1923–2018) — SPE (1968)

Co-authored *The Sound Pattern of English* with Chomsky (1968). Added an extensive articulatory feature system ([$\pm$ coronal], [$\pm$ anterior], etc.) and established **strictly ordered rules**.

2.4 Phonological Rule Notation

A → B / C _ D

"Sound A becomes B when it occurs between C and D"

Four Main Sound Change Processes

1. **Assimilation:** A sound becomes more like its neighbor. /ɪn + pʊt/ → [ɪmpʊt]
2. **Dissimilation:** Two similar sounds become different. Latin *peregrinus* → English *pilgrim*
3. **Deletion/Elision:** A sound disappears. *postman* /'pəʊstmən/ → ['pəʊsmən]
4. **Insertion/Epenthesis:** An extra sound is added. *warmth* → [wɔːmpθ]

Case Study: English /n/ Assimilation

Word	Underlying	Following Sound	Surface	Why
input	/ɪn + pʊt/	/p/ (bilabial)	[ɪmpʊt]	/n/ becomes bilabial [m]
intake	/ɪn + teɪk/	/t/ (alveolar)	[ɪnteɪk]	No change — /n/ is already alveolar
incomplete	/ɪn + kəmpli:t/	/k/ (velar)	[ɪŋkəmpli:t]	/n/ becomes velar [ŋ]

Syllable: Phonetic vs. Phonological Definitions & Phonotactic Possibilities

3.1 What is a Syllable?

A syllable is a single beat or pulse in speech. It has one vowel sound (or vowel-like sound) at its center, with optional consonants around it.

- *Cat* = 1 syllable [kæt]
- *Paper* = 2 syllables [peɪ.pər]
- *Banana* = 3 syllables [bə.næn.ə]

How to count syllables: Place your hand under your chin. Each time your jaw drops for a vowel sound = 1 syllable.

3.2 Phonetic vs Phonological Syllable

Feature	Phonetic Syllable	Phonological Syllable
Nature	Physical, acoustic (peaks of loudness)	Abstract, mental (grammar rules)
Defined by	Sonority peaks and chest pulses	Structure: Onset + Nucleus + Coda
Language-specific?	Mostly universal	Strictly language-specific rules
Boundaries	Fuzzy/continuous	Clear and categorical

Sonority

Sonority = how loud/resonant a sound is. The Sonority Hierarchy from most to least: Vowels > Glides (/j, w/) > Liquids (/r, l/) > Nasals (/m, n, ŋ/) > Fricatives > Stops.

Sonority Sequencing Principle (SSP): In a well-formed syllable, sonority rises from the onset to the nucleus and falls toward the coda.

3.3 Internal Structure of a Syllable

σ = Onset (optional consonants) + Rhyme [Nucleus (obligatory vowel) + Coda (optional consonants)]

- **Onset:** Consonant(s) before the vowel. Example: /tr/ in *train*
- **Nucleus:** The vowel — the core of every syllable. Can also be a syllabic consonant (/l/ in *bottle*)
- **Coda:** Consonant(s) after the vowel. Example: /ts/ in *cats*

3.4 Open vs Closed Syllables

- **Open:** Ends with a vowel (no coda) — *go, me, pa-per*. Vowel tends to be long.
- **Closed:** Ends with consonant(s) (has coda) — *cat, dog, help*. Vowel tends to be short.

3.5 Phonotactics

Phonotactics = the rules about which sound combinations are allowed in a language.

English Syllable Template: (C)(C)(C) V (C)(C)(C)(C) — up to 3 consonants in onset, up to 4 in coda.

3-Consonant Onset Rule

If an English syllable starts with 3 consonants: C₁ must be /s/, C₂ must be a voiceless stop (/p, t, k/), C₃ must be an approximant (/l, r, w, j/).

Examples: *spring* /spr-/ , *street* /str-/ , *split* /spl-/ , *scream* /skr-/ , *squeak* /skw-/

Maximum Coda (up to 4 consonants)

Examples: *texts* /teksts/ , *sixths* /sɪksθs/ , *glimpsed* /glɪmpst/

SSP Violation: /s/ + Stop

In *stop* /stop/, sonority drops from /s/ to /t/ before rising to the vowel. This breaks the SSP. Solution: /s/ is treated as an "appendix" outside the core syllable.

Maximal Onset Principle (MOP)

When splitting multisyllabic words, assign as many consonants as possible to the onset of the next syllable (if the resulting cluster is legal). Example: *diploma* → /dɪ.'pləʊ.mə/ (because /pl/ is a valid onset).

3.6 Bangla vs English Syllable Structure

Feature	Bangla	English
Complexity	Moderate (CV, CVC preferred)	Complex (up to CCCVCCCC)
Clusters	Very few in native words	Many clusters allowed
Loanword repair	<i>school</i> → <i>is-kul</i> (prothesis)	N/A

Connected Speech and Rules

4.1 What is Connected Speech?

Definition

Connected speech is natural, continuous spoken language where words blend together and sounds get modified. It is the opposite of saying each word separately (citation form).

Why does it happen? Not laziness — it is natural speech efficiency:

1. **Principle of Least Effort:** Our mouth saves energy by taking shortcuts
2. **Coarticulation:** The tongue prepares for the next sound before finishing the current one
3. **Stress-Timing:** English squeezes unstressed syllables to keep rhythm even

4.2 Linking (Catenation)

When the final consonant of one word joins smoothly to the initial vowel of the next word:

- "Turn it on" → [tɜː.nɪ.tən] (sounds like "tur-ni-ton")
- "Pick it up" → [pɪ.kɪ.tʌp] (sounds like "pi-ki-tup")
- "An apple" → [ə.næpl]

Vowel-to-Vowel Linking (Glide Insertion)

- **Linking /r/:** When spelling has an 'r' that's normally silent (in RP), it's pronounced before a vowel: "far away" → /fɑːr ə'weɪ/
- **Linking /w/:** After rounded vowels (/uː, əʊ, aʊ/): "go on" → /gəʊ w ɒn/
- **Linking /j/:** After front vowels (/iː, eɪ, aɪ/): "I am" → /aɪ j æm/

4.3 Intrusion

Like linking, but the inserted sound has **no letter in the spelling**:

- **Intrusive /r/:** "law and order" → /lɔː r ənd ɔːdə/ (no 'r' in "law"!)
- **Intrusive /w/:** "do it" → /duː w ɪt/
- **Intrusive /j/:** "see it" → /siː j ɪt/

4.4 Assimilation

Definition

A sound changes to become more like its neighbor in Place, Manner, or Voicing.

Three Directions

1. **Regressive (Anticipatory):** The following sound changes the preceding one (most common in English). "ten boys" → [tem bɔɪz]
2. **Progressive:** The preceding sound changes the following one. Plural -s: "cats" /kæts/ (voiceless after /t/), "dogs" /dɒgz/ (voiced after /g/)
3. **Coalescent:** Two sounds merge into a completely new sound. /t/ + /j/ → /tʃ/: "don't you" → /'dəʊntʃu/

Place Assimilation (Alveolars change before Bilabials and Velars)

Before Bilabial (/p, b, m/)	Before Velar (/k, g/)
"good boy" → [gʊb bɔɪ]	"good girl" → [gʊg gɜ:l]
"ten pounds" → [tem paʊndz]	"ten cups" → [ten kʌps]
"that pen" → [ðæp pen]	"not quite" → [nɒk kwɪt]

Coalescent Assimilation (Palatalization)

Combination	Result	Example
/t/ + /j/	/tʃ/	"don't you" → /'dəʊntʃu/; "meet you" → /'mi:tʃu/
/d/ + /j/	/dʒ/	"did you" → /'dɪdʒu/; "would you" → /'wʊdʒu/
/s/ + /j/	/ʃ/	"bless you" → /'bleʃu/
/z/ + /j/	/ʒ/	"as you know" → /əʒ ju: nəʊ/

4.5 Elision (Sound Deletion)

Definition

A sound that exists in careful speech is completely dropped in fast, natural speech.

/t/ and /d/ Deletion Rule

When /t/ or /d/ is between two other consonants (C + /t,d/ + C), it disappears:

- "next week" → [neks wi:k]
- "friendship" → ['frenʃɪp]
- "I can't swim" → [aɪ kɑ:n swɪm]

Exception: If the next word starts with a vowel, /t/ and /d/ stay.

Schwa/Vowel Deletion (Syncope)

- "camera" → /'kæmrə/ (3 → 2 syllables)
- "history" → /'hɪstri/
- "interesting" → /'ɪntrestɪŋ/
- "chocolate" → /'tʃɒklət/

/h/ Dropping in Weak Forms

Unstressed pronouns/auxiliaries lose their /h/: "tell him" → /'tel ɪm/, "ask her" → /'ɑ:sk ɜ:/

4.6 Glottalization

Replacing /t/ with a **glottal stop [ʔ]** — a brief closure of the vocal cords. Common in Cockney and Estuary English:

- "bottle" → ['bɒʔl], "little" → ['lɪʔl], "football" → ['fʊʔbɔ:l]

Three Theories of Glottalization

1. **Autosegmental Phonology:** The glottal feature [constricted glottis] spreads to the /t/ slot while the tongue-tip closure is delinked
2. **Articulatory Phonology:** The tongue-tip closure gesture is reduced/omitted; the glottal closure gesture takes over
3. **Usage-Based Theory:** High-frequency words like *bottle* store [ʔ] variants directly in the mental lexicon

4.7 Flapping (American English)

In General American, /t/ and /d/ between vowels (before an unstressed syllable) become a quick tap [ɾ]:

- "butter" → [ˈbʌɾər], "water" → [ˈwɑːɾər], "city" → [ˈsɪɾi]

4.8 Juncture

The acoustic clues that tell listeners where word boundaries are. Classic example:

"I scream" /aɪ + skri:m/	"Ice cream" /aɪs + kri:m/
Full /aɪ/ diphthong; /k/ is unaspirated (after /s/)	Short /aɪ/ (pre-fortis clipping); /k/ is aspirated [kʰ] (word-initial)

4.9 Stress-Timing & Rhythm

English is a **stress-timed** language: stressed syllables come at roughly equal intervals, regardless of how many unstressed syllables are in between. Unstressed syllables get squeezed. Bangla is **syllable-timed**: every syllable gets equal time.

4.10 Intonation

- **Rising** ↗: Yes/No questions, politeness, uncertainty — "Are you coming? ↗"
- **Falling** ↘: Statements, Wh-questions, finality — "I am ready. ↘"

4.11 Contractions & Reductions

- **Standard contractions:** I'm, you'll, she's, they'll
- **Fast speech reductions:** "going to" → *gonna*, "want to" → *wanna*, "got to" → *gotta*, "what are you" → *whatcha*

Strong vs Weak Form Words: Contractions, Elision & Assimilation

5.1 What are Weak Forms?

Definition

Weak forms are the reduced, unstressed pronunciations of function words (articles, prepositions, pronouns, auxiliaries, conjunctions). Vowels get reduced to schwa /ə/ or dropped entirely.

Why? English is stress-timed. Content words (nouns, main verbs, adjectives) get stress. Function words get squeezed into weak forms to keep the rhythm.

5.2 Master Weak Form Chart

Word	Strong Form	Weak Form	Example
to	/tu:/	/tə/ (before C), /tu/ (before V)	"Go to bed" /gəʊ tə 'bed/
and	/ænd/	/ənd/, /ən/, /n/	"Rock and roll" /'rɒk ən 'rɔːl/
of	/ɒv/	/əv/, /ə/	"Cup of tea" /ˌkʌp əv 'ti:/
from	/frɒm/	/frəm/	"Home from work"
that	/ðæt/	/ðət/	"I said that he could"
can	/kæn/	/kən/	"I can do it"
was	/wɒz/	/wəz/	"He was late"
for	/fɔ:/	/fə/	"Wait for me"
as	/æz/	/əz/	"As good as gold"
them	/ðem/	/ðəm/, /əm/	"Leave them alone"
have	/hæv/	/həv/, /əv/	"I should have gone"
a/an	/eɪ/, /æn/	/ə/, /ən/	"I need a pen"
the	/ði:/	/ðə/ (before C), /ði/ (before V)	"The book" /ðə bʊk/

5.3 When Must You Use the Strong Form?

- End of a sentence:** "What are you looking for?" → for = /fɔ:/
- Contrastive stress:** "I said AND, not OR!" → and = /ænd/
- Coordinated prepositions:** "to and from London" → /tu:/, /frɒm/
- Quoting the word itself:** "The word 'that' has four letters." → /ðæt/

5.4 Connection to Other Topics

Weak forms involve **elision** (dropping /h/ from *him*, *her*, *have*), **assimilation** (sounds changing to match neighbors), and **vowel reduction** (full vowels → schwa). These are all connected speech processes that work together.

IPA Transcription of Connected Speech

6.1 Putting It All Together

When transcribing connected speech, you must apply all the rules from Topics 1–5 simultaneously: weak forms, linking, assimilation, elision, and stress marking.

Step-by-Step Method

1. Identify **content words** (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs) — these keep their full (strong) pronunciation
2. Identify **function words** (to, and, of, the, can, was, etc.) — reduce them to **weak forms**
3. Mark **primary stress** (') on the main stressed syllable of content words
4. Apply **linking** — connect final consonants to following initial vowels
5. Apply **assimilation** — change alveolars before bilabials/velars
6. Apply **elision** — drop /t/, /d/ in consonant clusters; drop /h/ in weak forms
7. Apply **contractions** if appropriate

6.2 Worked Examples

Example 1: "I want to go to the shop and buy some bread and butter."

Word	Citation Form	Connected Speech	Process Applied
I	/aɪ/	/aɪ/	Content word — stays
want to	/wɒnt tu:/	/ˈwɒnə/	Reduction: "wanna"
go	/gəʊ/	/ˈgəʊ/	Content word
to the	/tu: ði:/	/tə ðə/	Both weak forms
shop	/ʃɒp/	/ˈʃɒp/	Content word
and	/ænd/	/ən/	Weak form + elision of /d/
buy	/baɪ/	/ˈbaɪ/	Content word
some	/sʌm/	/səm/	Weak form
bread and	/bred ænd/	/ˈbred ən/	/d/ elision + weak "and"
butter	/ˈbʌtə/	/ˈbʌtə/	Content word

Full transcription: /aɪ ˈwɒnə ˈgəʊ tə ðə ˈʃɒp ən ˈbaɪ səm ˈbred ən ˈbʌtə/

Example 2: "Can you give me a cup of tea?"

Citation: /kæn ju: gɪv mi: eɪ kʌp ɒv ti:/

Connected: /kæn jə ˈgɪv mi ə ˌkʌp əv ˈti:/

Processes: *can* → weak /kən/; *you* → weak /jə/; *me* → unstressed /mi/; *a* → /ə/; *of* → /əv/

Example 3: "Don't you think he should have told her?"

Connected: /ˈdəʊntʃə ˈθɪŋk i ˈʃʊd əv ˈtəʊld ə/

Processes: /t/+j/ coalescence → /tʃ/; *you* → /ə/; *he* → /i/ (h-dropping); *have* → /əv/; *her* → /ə/ (h-dropping)

Example 4: "She must have been at the office."

Connected: /ʃi 'mʌs əv bi:n ət ði 'ɒfɪs/

Processes: *must* → /t/ elision before /h/; *have* → /əv/; *been* → weak /bi:n/; *at* → weak /ət/; *the* → /ði/ (before vowel)

6.3 Common Patterns to Remember

Pattern	Rule	Example
C + V across words	Link them	"turn it" → [tɜ:.nɪt]
Alveolar + Bilabial	/t/→[p], /d/→[b], /n/→[m]	"good boy" → [gʊb bɔɪ]
Alveolar + Velar	/t/→[k], /d/→[g], /n/→[ŋ]	"good girl" → [gʊg gɜ:l]
/t,d/ + /j/	Coalescence	"did you" → /'dɪdʒu/
C + /t,d/ + C	/t,d/ deleted	"next day" → [neks deɪ]
Function word	Reduce to weak form	"and" → /ən/

Combined High-Yield Viva Question Bank

Below are key questions covering all 6 topics. Model answers are written in simple, clear English suitable for viva delivery.

Phonetics & Phonology

Q1. What is the difference between Phonetics and Phonology?

Phonetics studies the physical production and acoustic properties of speech sounds across all languages. Phonology studies how sounds function and form meaningful contrasts within a specific language's mental grammar.

Q2. What are the three branches of Phonetics? Which matters most for ELT?

Articulatory, Acoustic, and Auditory. Articulatory phonetics is most relevant to ELT because teachers need to show students where to place their tongue, lips, and teeth.

Q3. How are Phonetics and Phonology related?

They are complementary. Phonetics gives the physical raw material; Phonology gives the organizational rules. Neither is complete without the other.

Q4. What is the IPA and its golden rule?

The International Phonetic Alphabet, founded in 1886 by Paul Passy. Its golden rule: "One symbol for one sound, and one sound for one symbol."

Q5. What is the Schwa? Why is it the most common English sound?

The schwa /ə/ is a short, mid-central, neutral vowel made with a completely relaxed mouth. It's the most common because English is stress-timed, so all unstressed vowels tend to reduce to schwa.

Q6. Name the 3 parameters for describing consonants.

1. Voicing (voiced or voiceless), 2. Place of articulation (where the blockage is), 3. Manner of articulation (how air is released).

Q7. What is the difference between a Plosive and an Affricate?

Both start with complete blockage. In a plosive, the blockage is released suddenly with a burst. In an affricate, it is released slowly, creating friction.

Phonemes & Phones

Q8. What is the difference between a Phone and a Phoneme?

A phone is any physical speech sound, written in square brackets []. A phoneme is an abstract mental sound unit that can change meaning, written in slashes / /.

Q9. What is an Allophone? Give an example.

An allophone is a predictable variant of a phoneme that never changes meaning. Example: aspirated [pʰ] in "pin" and unaspirated [p] in "spin" are both allophones of /p/.

Q10. What is Trubetzkoy's Commutation Test?

Swap one sound for another in a word. If meaning changes, the sounds are separate phonemes. If meaning stays the same, they are allophones.

Q11. What is Neutralization? Give an example.

Neutralization is when two phonemes lose their contrast in a specific position. In German, /d/ and /t/ both become [t] at the end of a word — "Rad" and "Rat" sound identical.

Q12. What is Jakobson's Distinctive Feature Theory?

Sounds are bundles of binary features, each marked as present [+] or absent [-]. For example, /b/ is [+voiced] and /p/ is [-voiced].

Q13. What is the SPE formula?

Underlying Representation → [Phonological Rules] → Surface Representation. Published by Chomsky and Halle in 1968.

Syllable & Phonotactics

Q14. How do phonetic and phonological syllables differ?

A phonetic syllable is a physical peak of sonority. A phonological syllable is an abstract mental unit with structural positions: onset, nucleus, and coda.

Q15. What is the English syllable template?

(C)(C)(C) V (C)(C)(C)(C) — up to 3 consonants in the onset and up to 4 in the coda. Example: "spring" (CCCVC), "texts" (CVCCCC).

Q16. What are the rules for a 3-consonant onset?

C₁ must be /s/, C₂ must be a voiceless stop (/p, t, k/), C₃ must be an approximant (/l, r, w, j/). Example: "spring" /spr-/, "street" /str-/.

Q17. Why do Bangla speakers say "is-kul" for "school"?

Bangla phonotactics doesn't allow initial /sk-/ clusters. Speakers apply prothesis — inserting a vowel /i/ before the cluster — to create two legal syllables: is + kul.

Connected Speech

Q18. What is connected speech? Is it lazy speech?

Connected speech is continuous, natural spoken language where words blend and sounds change. It is NOT laziness — it is governed by the Principle of Least Effort and natural coarticulation.

Q19. What is the difference between Linking /r/ and Intrusive /r/?

Linking /r/ has an 'r' in the spelling that becomes audible before a vowel ("far away"). Intrusive /r/ has NO 'r' in the spelling — it is inserted purely as a glide ("law and order").

Q20. Explain Coalescent Assimilation with examples.

Two adjacent sounds merge into a new third sound. /t/ + /j/ → /tʃ/ ("don't you" → /'dəʊntʃu/). /d/ + /j/ → /dʒ/ ("did you" → /'dɪdʒu/).

Q21. What is the rule for /t, d/ elision?

When /t/ or /d/ sits between two other consonants (C + /t,d/ + C), it is deleted: "next week" → [neks wi:k]. But if a vowel follows, the /t,d/ stays.

Q22. How do "I scream" and "Ice cream" differ acoustically?

In "I scream," the /aɪ/ is long and /k/ is unaspirated (after /s/). In "Ice cream," /aɪ/ is shortened (pre-fortis clipping) and /k/ is aspirated [kʰ] (word-initial).

Q23. What is the difference between Stress-Timed and Syllable-Timed languages?

In stress-timed languages (English), stressed syllables occur at equal intervals — unstressed syllables get compressed. In syllable-timed languages (Bangla), every syllable gets roughly equal time.

Strong vs Weak Forms

Q24. What are Weak Forms?

Reduced, unstressed pronunciations of function words where vowels become schwa /ə/ or get dropped. Example: "and" /ænd/ → /ən/.

Q25. When must you use the Strong Form?

1. At the end of a sentence. 2. For emphasis or contrast. 3. In coordinated prepositions. 4. When quoting the word itself.

IPA Transcription

Q26. How do you transcribe connected speech step by step?

1. Identify content words (full pronunciation). 2. Reduce function words to weak forms. 3. Mark stress. 4. Apply linking. 5. Apply assimilation. 6. Apply elision. 7. Apply contractions.

Q27. Transcribe "He should have told them."

/hi 'ʃʊd əv 'təʊld əm/ — "he" keeps /h/ (sentence-initial), "should" → weak /ʃʊd/, "have" → /əv/ (h-drop), "them" → /əm/ (weak form).

Q28. What is Pre-fortis Clipping?

A vowel is shortened when followed by a voiceless consonant in the same syllable. Compare: "bead" [bi:d] (long) vs "beat" [bi:t] (shortened before voiceless /t/).

Q29. What is a Syllabic Consonant?

A consonant that acts as the core (nucleus) of a syllable instead of a vowel. English /n/ and /l/ often do this: "button" /'bʌtən/, "little" /'lɪtəl/.

Q30. What is a Minimal Pair and why is it useful in ELT?

Two words differing by one sound in the same position with different meanings (e.g., "ship" vs "sheep"). In ELT, minimal pairs help students identify and practice difficult sound contrasts.